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REQUEST FOR INFORMATION
Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services (CMS)

Assistant Secretary for Technology Policy / Office of the National Coordinator for Health Information Technology (ASTP/ONC)
RIN 0938-AV68

June 16, 2025

PREPARED BY

Customer Value Partners, LLC
805 Fifteenth Street, Suite 650
Washington, DC 20005
(703) 345-9100
www.cvpcorp.com
UEI/SAM: L6R3M86AFBB5

AUTHORIZED CVP OFFICIAL

Cheree Hodges
Vice President, Contracts
(703) 345-9138
contracts@cvpcorp.com

Signature:

SUBMITTED TO:

HHS-CMS
ASTP/ONC

Attention: CMS-0042-NC
P.O. Box 8013
Baltimore, MD 21244-8013.
HealthTechRFI@cms.hhs.gov

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TECHNOLOGY VENDORS, DATA PROVIDERS, AND NETWORKS

CVP Technological Expertise

Customer Value Partners (CVP), LLC is a healthcare and technology consulting firm helping clients improve quality, delivery, and access to healthcare data, research, and services. With expertise spanning Artificial Intelligence (AI), Machine Learning (ML), data architecture, statistical analysis, and healthcare informatics, our integrated team combines clinicians, clinical psychologists, and professionals with extensive CMS experience who collaborate with technical experts to develop client-driven solutions guided by subject matter expertise.

We believe that technology coupled with and informed by healthcare delivery subject matter expertise can transform the patient or beneficiary experience and facilitate healthcare access, health literacy, and informed decision-making on the part of both provider and patient. To that end, we have combined technology with clinical expertise to create technological solutions that advance better health outcomes for both Medicare and Medicaid beneficiaries.

Accelerating the time to respond to questions and making the government more responsive while reducing costs is a major priority for CMS. Artificial intelligence (AI) and machine learning (ML) can offer tremendous advantages in several areas to do just that. In prior years, CVP worked with Medicare to train ML models that predicted over 80% of hospital readmissions with an estimated $152M in potential savings**.** Today, CVP can apply these same skills using new generative AI and ML solutions for tasks like:

1. Enhance and accelerate hypothesis analysis and literature reviews.
2. Conduct independent, real-time analysis across multiple data sources.
3. Create personalized healthcare coverage guidance for beneficiaries, based on both the latest plan coverage and that beneficiaries' specific healthcare journey.

Below we present our targeted solution referenced in the third bullet point above: an AI-powered Medicare Coverage Assistant. This solution **directly addresses a critical challenge faced by Medicare beneficiaries** and their caregivers—navigating the complex landscape of Medicare coverage rules to determine eligibility for specific treatments and medical equipment. By combining official Medicare policies with personalized health histories, our solution offers tailored guidance that empowers beneficiaries to make informed healthcare decisions with confidence and minimal administrative burden.

Patient Needs

PC-1 What health management or care navigation apps would help you understand and manage your (or your loved ones) health needs, as well as the actions you should take?

b. If you had a personal assistant to support your health needs, what are the top things you would ask them to help with? In your response, please consider tasks that could be supported or facilitated by software solutions in the future.

Our team possesses lived experience that further enhances our understanding of the strengths and challenges in the current CMS health ecosystem. In discussing this RFI, one staff person noted her current role as a caregiver for a Medicare beneficiary, sharing that **an AI-driven personal assistant would be extremely helpful to help determine if specific treatments or medical equipment are covered**. Navigating Medicare's complex coverage rules is often time-consuming and frustrating for beneficiaries and their caregivers. Coverage determinations frequently depend on specific diagnoses, prior treatments, and other factors that vary from person to person, making generic information insufficient for informed decision-making. This feedback came from a health services researcher trying to navigate the current system, which made all of us sensitive to the challenges faced by less experienced users.

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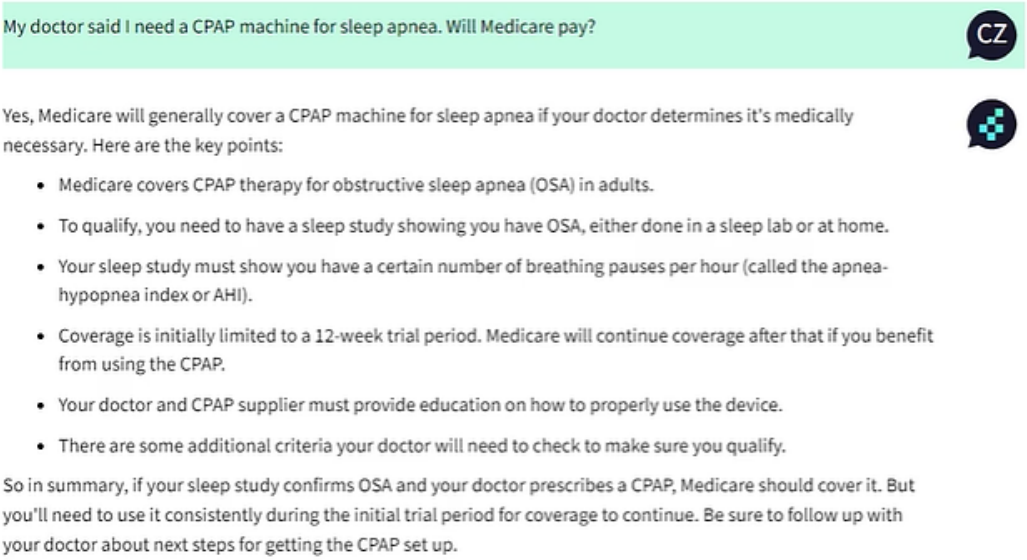
To address this, we propose an AI-powered Medicare Coverage Assistant that uses Medicare-specific coverage guidance in concert with personalized claims data from the CMS Blue Button project to provide highly tailored guidance to Medicare beneficiaries. This solution directly addresses the need identified for tools that help beneficiaries "understand and manage health needs".

As shown in ***Exhibit 1***, our organization has **already developed and deployed an AI-powered chatbot specifically designed to answer Medicare** Parts A and B coverage determination questions (e.g., "Will Medicare pay for a CPAP machine?"). It can help beneficiaries understand their coverage options through natural language conversations, eliminating the need to navigate complex Medicare documentation or spend hours on hold with customer service representatives. Building upon this proven foundation, we propose an enhanced version that would combine two powerful capabilities:

Exhibit 1: Our existing chatbot, designed to provide general guidance



- **Generative AI with Retrieval Augmented Generation (RAG)**: Our system will leverage advanced generative AI technology enhanced with RAG to provide accurate, contextually relevant information. Unlike basic chatbots that rely on pre-programmed responses, our solution will access an indexed copy of the official Medicare coverage database containing all National Coverage Determinations (NCDs) and Local Coverage Determinations (LCDs). This approach ensures that responses are grounded in official Medicare policies rather than general information. This architecture prevents hallucinations (when an AI creates false interpretations or made-up facts) and ensures that all coverage guidance provided is factually accurate, traceable to official Medicare documentation, and easy to update without retraining a large model.

Ask Medicare Demo

To see more about our existing Medicare chatbot, visit:
hellofranklin.com/askmedicare-demo
Password: *hKT52sQ5j^M

- **Medicare Blue Button Data Integration**: The innovative aspect of our proposal is the integration with the Blue Button 2.0 API, which will allow our system to incorporate the beneficiary's *Part A and B claims history* into the coverage determination process. By analyzing this personalized health data, the assistant can provide responses tailored to the individual's specific healthcare journey, including their diagnoses, procedures, and previous treatments. This personalization transforms generic coverage information into actionable guidance that accounts for the beneficiary's unique medical situation and Medicare utilization history.

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Benefits

Our Medicare Coverage Assistant offers three key benefits, shown in ***Exhibit 2,*** that directly address the challenges faced by Medicare beneficiaries and their caregivers.

Exhibit 2: Medicare Coverage Assistant Benefits

Benefit	Description
Personalized Coverage Determinations	The Medicare Coverage Assistant transforms generic coverage information into personalized guidance by analyzing the beneficiary's specific claims history and medical context. Rather than simply stating general Medicare policies, the system provides tailored responses that account for the individual's unique healthcare journey. For example, when asked about CPAP machine coverage, the assistant would first check the beneficiary's claims history to determine if they have already completed the required sleep study. If the study has been completed, the system would confirm this and explain the next steps for obtaining coverage. If not, it would explain this prerequisite and provide guidance on how to schedule a sleep study with a Medicare-covered provider. This personalization eliminates confusion and provides clear, actionable information specific to each beneficiary's situation.
Reduced Administrative Burden	Medicare beneficiaries and their caregivers currently spend hours annually navigating coverage questions, including lengthy phone calls with Medicare representatives (often with wait times exceeding 30 minutes), searching through complex coverage manuals, and visiting multiple websites to piece together information. Our Medicare Coverage Assistant dramatically reduces this burden by providing immediate, accurate answers to coverage questions through a simple conversational interface. Users can get answers in seconds rather than hours, eliminating the frustration of being transferred between departments or receiving inconsistent information from different sources. This time savings is particularly valuable for caregivers who are often balancing their caregiving responsibilities with work and other family obligations.
Accessibility for All Users	Medicare beneficiaries represent a diverse population with varying levels of technical proficiency and health literacy. Our conversational interface makes complex Medicare coverage information accessible to beneficiaries of all technical skill levels, including those with limited digital literacy or cognitive impairments. Users can interact with the system using natural language, asking questions in their own words without needing to understand Medicare terminology or navigate complicated menu systems. The system could also support voice interaction for users with visual impairments or mobility limitations that make typing difficult. Additionally, all responses are provided in clear, jargon-free language with definitions of technical terms when necessary, ensuring that information is truly accessible to all users regardless of their background or familiarity with healthcare systems.

Implementation Plan

Data Integration Phase

Our implementation will begin with a comprehensive data integration phase focused on establishing secure and compliant connections to Medicare's Blue Button 2.0 API. This phase includes:

- **Establishing secure connections to the Blue Button 2.0 API**: We will implement OAuth 2.0 authentication protocols and FHIR-based API connections to securely access Medicare claims data. This will include developing robust error handling mechanisms and implementing connection monitoring to ensure reliable data retrieval.
- **Developing authentication mechanisms for beneficiary data access**: We will create a user-friendly authentication flow that allows beneficiaries to securely authorize access to their Medicare data. This will include multi-factor authentication options, clear consent screens explaining data usage, and the ability to revoke access at any time, ensuring full compliance with CMS security requirements.

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- **Creating data processing pipelines that maintain HIPAA compliance**: Our system will implement end-to-end encryption for all data in transit and at rest. We will establish comprehensive audit logging capabilities to track all data access events and implement data minimization principles to ensure only necessary information is processed. All data processing will occur within HIPAA-compliant environments with appropriate technical safeguards.
- **Implementing efficient data storage and preprocessing for real-time access:** We will store claims data in a database optimized for healthcare data queries. Our pre-processing pipeline will automatically analyze claims history to flag important medical conditions, procedures, and equipment relevant to coverage determinations. This preprocessing step will create a structured profile of each beneficiary's medical history, making it easy to quickly identify whether they've met prerequisites for specific coverage requirements. The system will include caching mechanisms to ensure rapid data retrieval during conversations, allowing the assistant to provide immediate responses even when analyzing complex coverage scenarios that require reviewing multiple years of claims history.

Knowledge Base Development

The knowledge base will serve as the foundation for accurate coverage determinations and will be developed through:

- **Creating an automated process to extract Medicare Coverage data**: We will develop a crawler to retrieve and parse coverage information from the Medicare Coverage Database (https://www.cms.gov/medicare-coverage-database/search.aspx). This automated process will run on a regular schedule to ensure our knowledge base remains current with the latest Medicare policies.
- **Indexing content and ensuring accuracy**: After extraction, all content will be processed through our proprietary natural language processing (NLP) pipeline to identify key coverage criteria, prerequisites, and exclusions. We will implement a verification system to ensure only the latest Local Coverage Determinations (LCDs) and National Coverage Determinations (NCDs) are included in the knowledge base, with automated detection of superseded policies. A team of Medicare policy experts will conduct regular quality assurance reviews to validate the accuracy of the indexed information.

AI Assistant Enhancement

Building upon our existing work, we will implement several key enhancements:

- **Leveraging our existing Medicare coverage chatbot**: We will begin with our proven chatbot platform that has already demonstrated success in answering Medicare Parts A and B coverage questions. This provides a solid foundation of conversational AI capabilities specifically configured for Medicare terminology and policies.
- **Implementing a claims-aware search agent**: When a beneficiary asks a coverage question, our system will automatically initiate a search agent that analyzes their claims history through our database. If necessary, this agent will identify relevant prior procedures, diagnoses, and treatments that may impact coverage determinations for the current inquiry. For example, when asked about CPAP coverage, the system will search for sleep study records and related diagnoses of obstructive sleep apnea (OSA).
- **Enhancing the RAG process with personalized data**: We will extend our current retrieval augmented generation (RAG) architecture to incorporate three key data sources: the user's question, relevant Medicare coverage determinations from our knowledge base, and the beneficiary's personal Blue Button claims data. This enhanced RAG process will use a sophisticated prompt engineering approach to generate responses that accurately reflect both official Medicare policies and the beneficiary's specific healthcare context. The system will clearly distinguish between general policy information and personalized guidance based on claims history.

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Testing and Validation

Our testing and validation process will ensure the system delivers accurate, helpful, and secure guidance:

- **Conducting comprehensive accuracy testing**: We will develop a test suite of common Medicare coverage scenarios with known determinations, spanning various medical specialties and equipment categories. Each scenario will be tested against our system to verify the accuracy of responses. We will establish a minimum accuracy threshold of 95% before proceeding to user testing.
- **Performing extensive user testing**: We will recruit a diverse panel of Medicare beneficiaries and caregivers representing various demographics, technical skill levels, and health conditions to participate in guided testing sessions. These sessions will evaluate both the accuracy of information provided and the usability of the interface. We will collect detailed feedback through standardized questionnaires and conduct in-depth interviews to identify areas for improvement.
- **Validating privacy and security protections**: Our security team will conduct penetration testing, vulnerability assessments, and comprehensive security audits to ensure all data is properly protected.

Deployment and Continuous Improvement

Our deployment strategy focuses on accessibility and ongoing enhancement:

- **Initial rollout as web and mobile applications**: We will launch both web-based and native mobile applications (iOS and Android) to ensure accessibility across all devices. The web application will be designed with responsive principles to function well on any screen size, while the mobile applications will leverage platform-specific capabilities for enhanced user experience. All interfaces will be designed following accessibility best practices to ensure usability for beneficiaries with disabilities.
- **Implementing a feedback collection system**: Each interaction with the Medicare Coverage Assistant will include an option for users to rate the helpfulness of responses and provide specific feedback. This feedback will be systematically collected, categorized, and analyzed to identify patterns and opportunities for improvement. Our development team will review this feedback weekly and prioritize enhancements based on user needs.
- **Maintaining an up-to-date knowledge base**: We will establish an automated monitoring system that checks for updates to Medicare coverage policies daily. When changes are detected, our knowledge base will be updated accordingly, and all affected content will be flagged for review by our Medicare policy experts. This ensures that beneficiaries always receive the most current information about their coverage options. Additionally, we will conduct quarterly comprehensive reviews of the entire knowledge base to ensure continued accuracy and relevance.

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